

back casting: what do we want and how do we get there?

Define a future scenario

What does the world look like in, say, 10–20 years?

people primarily meet in real life (coffee shops, restaurants, bars, parks), rather than relying on dating apps. Work life

Work backward

What had to happen right before that? And before that?

Identify actions today

What needs to start now to make that future possible?

2026- 2028

- people feel burned out from the endless swiping and superficial interactions, so they start deleting dating apps.
- this leads to more loneliness, as people aren't getting instant validation anymore from dating apps.

what can we do to make socializing fun again?

- socializing events
- community based apps

2028-2036

- in the year 2028, there is an increase in social gatherings because spaces are being designed for connection.
- people start resenting AI and dating apps for making everything feel superficial and surface level.
- more clubs (ex. sports, music) - catered towards different age groups

2036-2040

- people use dating apps less and depend on more on community events/real-life interactions.
- dating apps still exist but its usage decreases over the years.

Backcasting
- Preferred scenario

Dating apps are pretty much obsoleteand in person interactions and connectios are the main way people are finding love.

Three-step technique for rapid future forecasting

step 1: main driver of change:
switching from social connections to digital relationships

step 2: future industry of interest:
dating apps online

step 3:
surface level connections

Identify the current or emerging trends, forces, and events your scenario and artifact are based on

Target Audience — who is this for?
Younger Gen from 25-30

✓ How does it work?

✓ Artifact format: website, exhibition, product prototype, commercial, role-playing skit, workshop, or other immersive format

✓ Presentation of artifact with explanation of your process

Identify the current or emerging trends, forces, and events your scenario and artifact are based on

current trends:

Contextual Scenario — define the “world” your artifact exists in. What is it like? Is it preferred, projected, possible, or preposterous?
Preferred - By 2046, dating apps as we know them have largely disappeared. People meet in physical spaces - coffee shops, bars, parks, intentionally designed. community venues - rather than through algorithmic matching.
Connection has become slower, more dependent on physical proximity and chance encounter, and more shaped by design of social spaces.
Lonliness still exists but is being addressed at the level of urban infrastructure rather than software inerfaces.
Projected -

Three-Step Technique for Rapid Future Forecasting

Step 1: Pick any main driver of change (e.g., type of technology, policy).

Step 2: Combine it with a future topic/area/industry of interest.

Step 3: Ask how that driver will impact the chosen topic in the future.



Autonomous Vehicles

+



Restaurant Industry

=

CONCEPT

- In-person social hubs for meetin people (post-dating app culture)

CORE IDEA - BRAINSTORMING

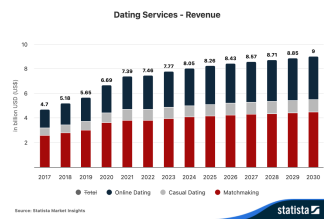
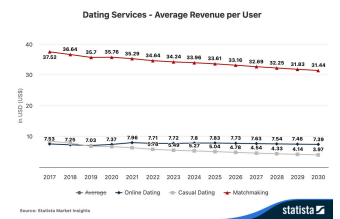
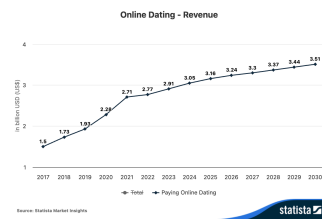
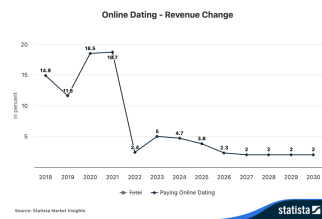
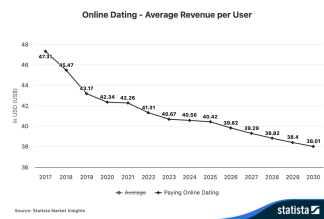
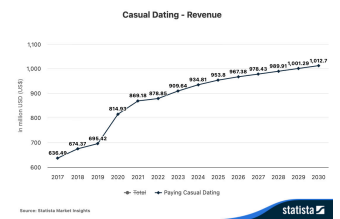
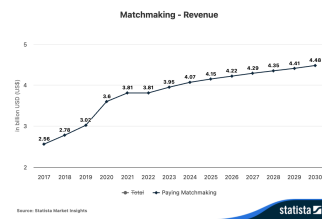
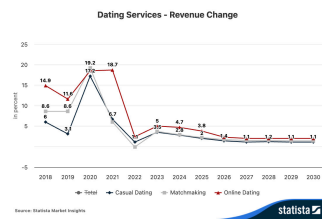
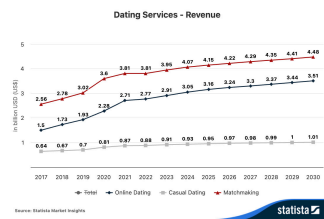
- network of physical "social hubs" designed specifically for meeting people in-person
- feels similar to a members club, but more accessible and less exclusive
- focus on shared activities or experiences rather than "dating"
 - tennis, pickelball, billiards
 - social events
 - group classes (fitness, creative workshops)
 - lounge and café areas
- designed to replace the role of dating apps used to play
- would be represented through a website to explain the features of these social hubs and where to find your local location
- phone/technology free environment
- layout encourages movement, visibility, and natural interaction
- WHY
 - society moved away from dating apps due to distrust, burnout, or over-reliance on technology
 - people still want structure when meeting others, so this replaces that structure physically
- WHAT MAKES IT PROVOACATIVE
 - replaces digital matching with designed physical environments
 - connection is influenced by space and activity, not algorithms
 - safety is built into the system through verification and background checks
 - removes anonymity, making interactions feel more accountable
 - raises the question of whether connection is more "authentic" or still being controlled, just in a different way

TARGET AUDIENCE

- younger demographic (20s-30s)
- people who are tired or distrustful of digital dating
- individuals looking for more natural, in-person ways to meet others
- people who value social interaction but want a structured, safe environment
- could also expand to older age groups or different communities over time

HOW IT WORKS

- users sign up and are verified before gaining access
- background checks are required to create a sense of safety and trust
- entry is through membership/subscription
 - costs less than a typical membership club, but small fee so there is funding to throw social events
 - funded partially by the government after social interaction become so abismal after technology advances
- locations exist in major cities and are designed intentionlly for interaction
 - company that runs it hosts events in smaller cities that partner with local establishments



<https://www.statista.com/outlook/emo/dating-services/online-dating/worldwide>

<https://www.statista.com/outlook/emo/dating-services/worldwide>

<https://www.statista.com/outlook/emo/dating-services/casual-dating/worldwide>

<https://www.statista.com/outlook/emo/dating-services/matchmaking/worldwide>

<https://www.wgsn.com/insight/article/69aee8262a6d96555356f46c>

- **Gen Z 2027: Companionship as a Service**
- talks about Gen Z's growing trust with AI and how that could move forward into AI relationships/companionship

!!!! <https://www.wgsn.com/insight/article/69663117ded3a15c6cf5d92b>

- **Youth Priorities 2027**
- also talks about companionship with AI
- talks a lot about characteristics of the younger generations, their current traits, and where they're headed

<https://www.wgsn.com/tech/article/69df9c0d4faec9e57d48c7ec>

- **Trend Alert: Apps for the Shared Table**
- talks about hybrid technology increasing
- younger generations are lonely and wanting more experiences and ways to meet new people
 - article talks about meeting people where you can dine with them using hybrid technology

<https://www.wgsn.com/insight/article/6901207976e6074b32dd7b34>

- **Valentine's Day 2027**
- "As loneliness rises worldwide, consumers are reimagining Valentine's Day rituals to foster a sense of belonging, validation and joy at a time when disconnection is the norm. Looking beyond romance, however, many consumers are also celebrating a wider spectrum of connections, from embracing self-love and platonic friendships to those with other significant others (OSOs), all of which offer brands opportunities to create products and experiences that meet these shifting consumer needs during this holiday event."
- "From 'Galentine's' gatherings to self-care retreats, consumers are leaning into the idea that love extends beyond romance, and that nurturing it in all its forms is vital to their wellbeing."

<https://www.wgsn.com/insight/article/6901207976e6074b32dd7b34/strategy/6902333276e6074b32df84d2>

- **Valentine's Day 2027 - Embrace the range of relationships worthy of celebration**

Showcase the real and the raw

Validate the messy reality of love by spotlighting imperfect moments, inviting candid vulnerability and designing experiences with transparent, realistic promises that reduce pressure and boost trust. 35% of Bumble users say that realistic and optimistic dating content makes them feel hopeful about their own love lives (Bumble). Highlight unpredictable, playful or imperfect moments, such as spontaneous gestures, quirky date ideas or shared moments of vulnerability or laughter. This normalises the ups and downs of relationships and connects with audiences on a sentimental level, allowing for a deeper understanding and emotional resonance.

Celebrate love beyond romance

Acknowledge that genuine closeness isn't limited to romantic relationships and often resides in the rhythm of daily life. Honour other significant others (OSOs), such as teachers, mentors, neighbours and business partners, by noticing and celebrating the small moments that turn ordinary interactions into meaningful memories. Considering that 86% of singles say humour, inside jokes and shared moments are key ways to show affection, brands should empower customers to showcase their appreciation for the most important people in their lives (Bumble).

Create moments to celebrate parents

Position Valentine's Day as an opportunity to recognise all meaningful relationships. Parents — whether mothers, fathers, step-parents or other caregivers — play a central role in shaping how people experience and share love, and they deserve recognition. By designing products and experiences that meet the emotional needs of these relationships, brands can offer tools that make gratitude tangible, from a quality time together to meaningful keepsakes. Highlight the importance of guidance and support which parents provide, and rethink traditional Valentine's messaging to celebrate the first love in people's lives.

- this article also shows examples of what brands did for their valentine's campaigns
 - ex. Sweethearts' "Love in this Economy" with messages about splitting rent as opposed to cute phrases around love in relationships

<https://www.wgsn.com/insight/article/6901207976e6074b32dd7b34/strategy/69b7fb97185c6063ea4db082>

- **Empower Positive Sensuality**

Position self-pleasure as a tool for self-awareness and emotional literacy

Reframe Valentine's Day beyond couple-centric narratives by encouraging individuals to explore their bodies, desires and boundaries without shame. Develop educational content, guided reflections, or expert-led conversations that frame solo intimacy as a healthy, informed practice grounded in consent and autonomy. Encourage open dialogue around pleasure as part of wellbeing, helping individuals build confidence, reduce stigma and understand their own needs before communicating them to others.

Use games to boost safe exploration and communication

Position games as tools for playful intimacy and emotional openness. Worldwide, 84% of Gen Z daters on Hinge are seeking new ways to build emotional intimacy (Hinge). Create card decks, conversation prompts, or light physical challenges designed for couples or new partners to explore their boundaries and fantasies in a structured, low-pressure environment. Foster curiosity, humour and communication.

Encourage imagination and romantic fantasy

<https://app.stylus.com/consumer-attitudes/three-new-ai-matchmaking-apps-streamline-online-dating>

<https://app.stylus.com/pop-culture-media/internet-trends-101-new-romance>

43%

Globally, 43% of single people think it is getting harder to find love

Survey, 2022

- ✓ **Industry/Area Definition** (what are we referring to [defining the industry], what characterizes this industry, what does this area encompass)
- ✓ **Current Industry Situation** (projected growth or decline, current major players, relevant audience/participants, a few important and relevant facts relating to the future state of your industry which will inform your future scenarios)
- ✓ **Identify & Research Trends** defining your industry
- ✓ **Key drivers and trends** (micro, macro, mega) that could significantly impact the industry's future, including changes in technology, social attitudes, political and economic factors, and environmental issues (STEEP)

- ✓ Develop a Futures Wheel to map the main implications of one selected driver, including third-order consequences
- ✓ Use Three-Step Rapid Forecasting to identify potential consequences of two additional drivers that will inform your future scenario
- ✓ Cone of Plausibility (Futures Cone): Develop three analyses (preposterous, preferred, and projected) and communicate each through a highly detailed scenario based on your research. Incorporate one wildcard into your preposterous scenario
- ✓ Backcasting — apply this tool to your preferred scenario planning
- ✓ Business Artifact from the Future — must relate to a business (existing or imagined). It should be provocative and immersive
- ✓ Contextual Scenario — define the “world” your artifact exists in. What is it like? Is it preferred, projected, possible, or preposterous?
- ✓ Identify the current or emerging trends, forces, and events your scenario and artifact are based on
- ✓ Target Audience — who is this for?
- ✓ How does it work?
- ✓ Artifact format: website, exhibition, product prototype, commercial, role-playing skit, workshop, or other immersive format
- ✓ Presentation of artifact with explanation of your process

- Travel improving - will people we outsourcing and meeting/dating people from around the world
 - Think about how on dating apps now you can put a radius of how close people are or if you're travelling you can change your location
- *The Good Place* - concept that they are paired with their soulmate in heaven → main characters did not speak the same language but it was "automatically translated"
 - apple airpods now have translating feature to automatically translate other languages for you
- Look at dating shows now
 - The age differences show... are people living longer and can date at drastically different age now... is medical technology advancing so that women can have kids later
- Technology impact on people today...less
- Climate change → not wanting to bring people into the world/have kids
- Pushing back age where people get married
- are there stats on increasing use of dating apps → can this tie into the AI stats
 - if its going down → ties into our idea of people being alone in the future

Social, economic, environmental

Statista - dating in the future

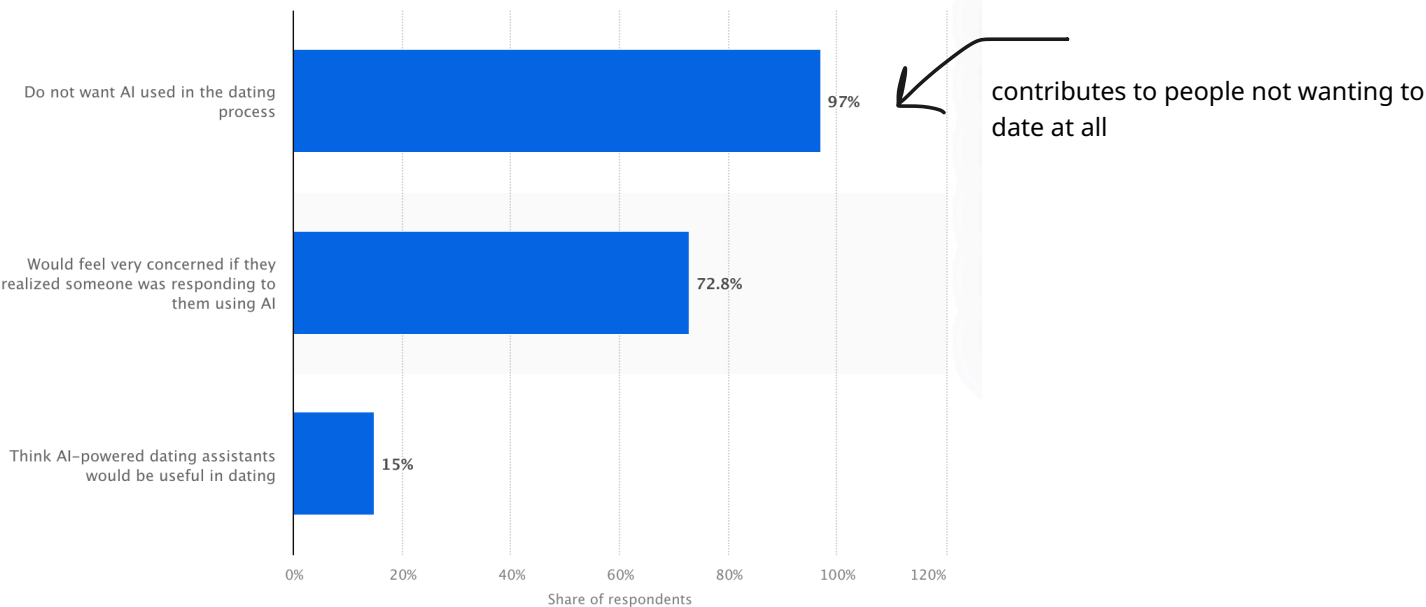
<https://www.statista.com/statistics/195955/divorce-rate-in-the-united-states-since-1990/>

US online dating users

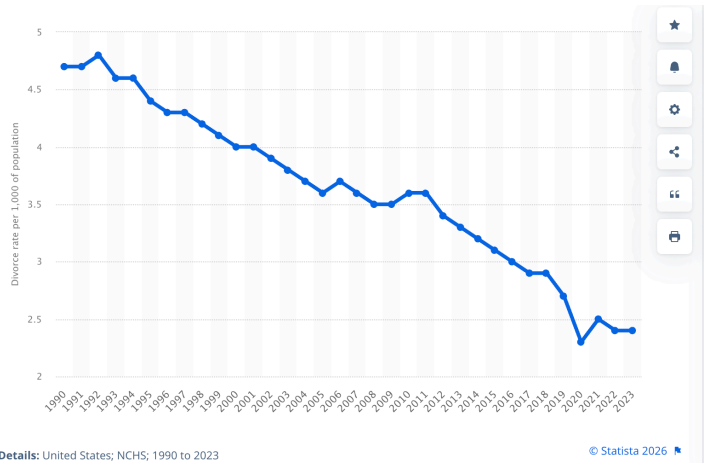
60.5 million

Industry revenue

1.39 bn\$



Divorce Rates



Divorce rates are going down because people are marrying less

Marriage rate in the United States from 1990 to 2023 (per 1,000 population)

